

Example Product Principles

This is a draft set of principles to help guide product decisions as we continue to build and grow CompanyX. They are not necessarily hard rules, but considerations to use when facing a tradeoff. We should think about these at every step of our development process (so it's worth getting them right).

Non-negotiables

1. We prioritize user safety, compliance, and privacy above all else. This means our teams will spend time building tools to become compliant before working on features to make CompanyX better. Three main guidelines beyond basic common sense of not putting our patients at risk:
 - a. **Compliance** - we maintain 100% compliance with relevant law and regulation at all times
 - b. **Privacy** - we provide a clear privacy policy (where it's different or more restrictive than compliance)
 - c. **Reliability** - CompanyX should always reliably deliver videos and adherence data, even in low connectivity settings. We should have redundancies in place and prioritize reliability of existing users over adoption of new ones.

Mission and impact

1. **Improve Outcomes:** Our highest mission for CompanyX is to improve outcomes. Everything we do should ultimately be in the service of this goal. We think there are 4 big ways to do this:
 - a. **Metric X:** We believe X is one of our best levers to drive outcomes, and will prioritize features that do this.
 - b. **Lowering barriers:** We also believe lowering barriers to accessing X drives improved outcomes, and will prioritize features that do this, like optimizing for low connectivity and offline situations, as well as ...
 - c. **Saving users time:** Reducing the time it takes for people to do their jobs is critical to our success and something that will improve the usability of our tools
2. **Impact First:** In our business, our impact is almost entirely aligned with our revenue model, so these rarely come into conflict. The more contracts we sign, the more we can grow and have an impact. However, if we do encounter a tradeoff, we will prioritize impacts over revenue, following CompanyX values of impact, , profit, in that order, as long as it sustains further impact in the future.
3. **Evidence Based:** We will use academic research to inform our work where possible, and our own data to inform it when published research isn't available. If we can't prove with evidence that a feature measurably improves outcomes, we should at least attempt to measure the size of the problem with data to be able to articulate the potential impact.
4. **Users come first (then providers, then sponsors)** - ---

How we build

1. **Build the thing that serves the most people most of the time** - we want to prioritize features that meet most of the needs for most of our users. This means that where possible, we'll avoid building features that need to be gatekept to a small number of users, aka feature flagged. If we do build a new behavior for a client that adds value, we'll consider building in a way that adds value to as many other customers as possible rather than hiding it for them, unless it clearly creates unnecessary complication.
2. **Launch first build second** - We follow an agile, iterative product development cycle. As long as it's safe, we want to put our ideas into the world as soon as possible in order to get feedback and validate them, rather than spending months designing only to find they don't work as expected. This means building prototypes that are as lightweight as possible, testing in small environments first, then iterating and expanding when validated.
 - a. **Code wins arguments** - wherever possible, the best way to determine whether to move forward with a feature is to build, test, and prove its value.
3. **Do less with less** - Small engineering teams are often pushed to do more with less, but that leads to constant stretching. We aim to do less with less, using our limited resources on a limited number of things that we think will drive the most value. We don't squeeze our team to the limit to maximize output. We don't try to build every feature a client asks for - clients are not software designers - that's our specialty. We listen deeply to our clients' needs, and we build for them to solve their problems.
 - a. **SAAS > Services** - Where possible, we aim to build software, not an end to end service model. Our product should work and add value out of the box, and not depend on us providing in-person service (project management). In some cases, the principle of improving outcomes and having impact (above) may depend on us taking a more hands on approach. When we do this, we should do so with a small team.
 - b. **Consider removing unused features** - We aim for simplicity and user success over feature count. This means that if features are not being used to improve outcomes for our users, we should consider if we can have more impact by removing them and focusing our limited resources on improving ones that are high value.
4. **We are a software-first team, and we empower engineers** - We focus on defining the problem before we iterate on solutions. This includes bringing engineering into the discovery process and learning directly from our users, setting goals that the team is aligned on, and empowering the entire team to consider and put forth solutions.
5. **Blameless culture** - every team member is accountable for the success of CompanyX, and we tackle failures as opportunities to learn and improve systems.

Design principles

1. **Instructions are a last resort** - Our products should be intuitive and usable without the need for instruction manuals or step by step videos to tackle basic functions. The best process is no process (i.e. we should automate as much as possible).
2. **Avoid filling forms** - We think forms are the lowest bar of technology helping users. If we see a long page of text input fields, we should question our approach and consider options that make our users' lives easier. - Making a note to capture ... "technology should be an enabler - not something that collects data....?"